THE NOBULOUS SET · GAME ONE

BAT
Build-a-Tyrant

Four scientists, one boss, and every failure makes it stronger.

Four Lab Rats work their benches in Nobulous' laboratory, resolving Encounters and bolting salvaged Upgrades onto themselves. Every Encounter they fail donates material to the thing growing in the tank. Five Splices and it wakes up. Then they have to kill it.

COMPONENTS

- 4 double-sided Lab Rat cards
- 20 Encounter cards
- 16 regular Upgrade cards (4 each of Power, Mobility, Defense, Senses)
- 8 Specimen cards
- 7 Tyrant Attack cards
- 1 double-sided Buff HP dial (1–4 / 5–8)
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the 3 stat dice — Health, Strategy and Recovery — and the Chip

SETUP

1. Choose one side of each of the four Lab Rat cards. That side is fixed for the game. Place all four Rats in a row — every Rat is in play at once.
2. Give each Rat one Purple, one Blue, one Green and one Yellow die. These are that Rat's **personal dice** and stay at its own workbench.
3. Set the Red die aside. Red is communal and belongs to no Rat.
4. Choose a difficulty. **The Tyrant always has 20 Health.** Difficulty adds **Buff HP** and changes how many Specimens are in the deck:

DIFFICULTY	SPECIMENS	BUFF HP	WIN RATE
Easy	2	0	~84%
Standard	3	2	~78%
Hard	4	4	~70%
Brutal	4	6	~60%
Nobulous	4	8	~51%

   Shuffle that many random Specimens into the 16 regular Upgrades. Return the rest to the box. Set the Buff HP dial to the chosen value, or leave it in the box at Easy.
5. Shuffle the 20 Encounters into a face-down deck. Leave space beside it for Splices — Upgrades spliced into the Tyrant are stacked there face-up.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

Five Splices awaken the Tyrant. You cannot avoid this — the game is about *which* five cards it gets and *what shape your Rats are in* when it stands up. Defeat the Tyrant to win.

A TURN

1. Reveal the next Encounter card.
2. Reveal 2 cards from the Upgrade deck. If either is a Specimen, increase this Encounter's Target by **+1** (once only, even if both are Specimens).
3. Choose which Rat is active, *after* seeing the Encounter and the two Upgrades. The same Rat may be chosen on consecutive turns.
4. Resolve any ability that triggers after selection and before dice are committed.
5. Commit dice, roll, and resolve (below).
6. Exhaust the committed personal dice, resolve Red and any borrowed die, then recover dice equal to that Rat's REC.

Committing and rolling

STR is the number of Strategy phases, not a die count. Base STR 2 gives you the initial roll plus one further phase in which to reroll misses and, if the Encounter allows, commit more dice.

The active Rat may commit any number of its own available dice, plus Red if it holds it, plus at most one borrowed die. Hits and Crits count toward the Encounter Target; a Crit is 2 successes.

SUCCESS

Meet the Target and satisfy any printed restriction. The active Rat takes **one** of the two revealed Upgrades (max 3 Upgrades per Rat). Discard the other.

FAILURE

Splice the stronger revealed Upgrade into the Tyrant. Discard the other. If the two are equal in value, choose randomly.

Zero-dice turns

A Rat may be selected and commit nothing. The Encounter fails automatically and the stronger Upgrade is Spliced. Recovery still happens. This is a legal choice, not a rest action — it gives no bonus.

BORROWING

The active Rat may borrow **one** available non-Red die from another Rat. The more Upgrades the borrower already holds, the worse the die it is allowed to take:

UPGRADES HELD	MAY BORROW	BANISH RISK
0	Purple, Blue, Green or Yellow	17%
1	Blue, Green or Yellow	33%
2	Green or Yellow	50%
3	Yellow only	67%

After the Encounter resolves, roll the borrowed die by itself. On a miss it is **banished** — removed from the game permanently. On a hit or Crit it returns to its owner exhausted.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Banished dice never come back. Expect to lose two or three personal dice over a game. A well-equipped Rat borrowing Yellow is gambling badly; an empty Rat borrowing Purple usually gets away with it.

THE RED DIE

- Red is communal, is never banished, and belongs to no workbench.
- If the active Rat holds Red, it may commit it normally.
- After Red is used it is **set aside** rather than exhausted.
- At the start of the next turn, after the active Rat has been chosen, place the set-aside Red on any **non-active** Rat.

Red therefore takes planning: a Rat can only use it on a later turn, when it happens to be selected while holding it.

AWAKENING THE TYRANT

The Tyrant awakens the moment it reaches **5 Splices**. Move the five spliced Upgrades into a row — these are the Tyrant's Upgrades — and begin the battle.

Splicing Machine Malfunction. If the Encounter deck runs out first, randomly select enough unused Upgrade cards to bring the Tyrant to exactly 5 Splices, apply them, and begin the battle. Running out of *Upgrade* cards is not a malfunction — reshuffle the Upgrade discard instead.

THE TYRANT BATTLE

The Tyrant has **20 Health** plus the Buff HP set by difficulty, REC 3, and a dice pool of 2 Purple, 2 Blue, 1 Green and 1 Yellow. It fights using the five Splices it was given.

The Rats now fight as a team from a **shared battle dice pool**, but each round begins by choosing one surviving Rat as the attacker. That Rat uses its own ability and its own held Upgrades.

Shuffle the 7 Tyrant Attack cards face-down. At the start of each Tyrant attack — after the Rat turn has fully resolved — reveal the top card and apply it, then discard it. Reshuffle the discard if the deck empties.

THE CARD IS HIDDEN ON PURPOSE

You commit dice and decide whether to tap an Upgrade *without knowing what is coming*. Revealing the attack in advance was tested and turns the fight into a defensive slog roughly twice as long.

- Unless a card says otherwise, the Tyrant attacks the **active Rat**.
- Damage is absorbed by that Rat's untapped Upgrades before reaching its Health.
- A **tapped** Upgrade cannot absorb damage. Tapping for effect costs you armour.
- The Tyrant's Defense Upgrades must be broken through before its other Upgrades or its Health.
- Rats may attack without activating any Upgrade.

Buff HP

Buff HP must be removed before any damage reaches the Tyrant's 20 Health. Set the dial so the chosen number reads upright, and rotate it **90° clockwise for each point of damage** dealt while Buff HP remains — the number that reads upright is always what is left. At 5, flip the card to its other face. When the last Buff HP is removed, put the dial aside; further damage comes off Health normally.

WHY A SEPARATE TRACK

Buff HP is armour, not stamina. It absorbs the opening exchange — the rounds where your Upgrades are untapped and your dice are fresh — so a harder game does not simply last longer, it makes the strong part of your battle count for less.

Reduce the Tyrant to 0 Health to win. If every Rat is knocked out, the Tyrant wins.

CARRYING BAT FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the NRJ campaign. Skip otherwise.

After a successful battle, **retain up to 3 Upgrade cards held by Rats that survived**, of which at most 1 may be a Specimen. Upgrades held by knocked-out Rats, and every card spliced into the Tyrant, become **candidates**. If fewer than 3 eligible Upgrades survive, fill the remaining slots with candidates so BAT contributes 6 cards in total.

Winning is not enough — winning with your Rats intact is what banks material for the finale.